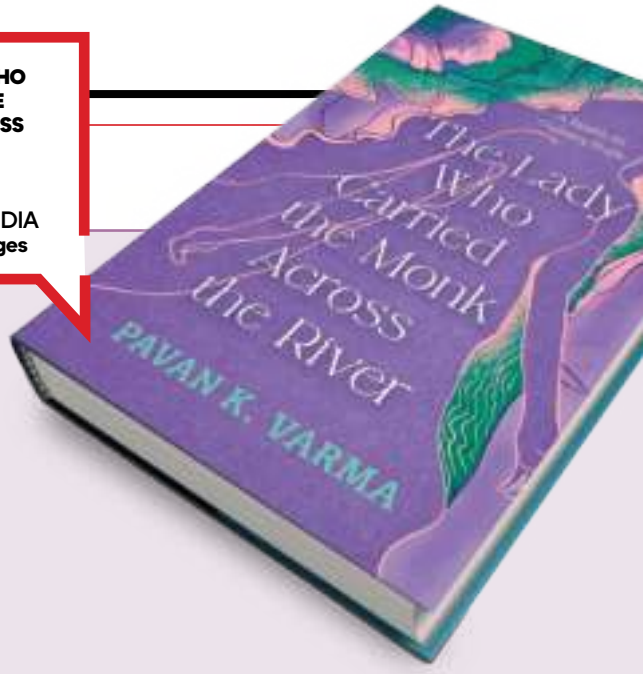
THE LADY WHO CARRIED THE MONK ACROSS THE RIVER
By Pavan K. Varma
PENGUIN INDIA
₹499; 160 pages



BOOKS ▼

NO ORDINARY PARABLE

PAVAN K. VARMA weaves a deceptively simple tale, layered with symbolism and meaning

Pavan K. Varma's impressive journey, with a third eye on the 'great' Indian middle class, and on 'being' and then 'becoming' Indian, has led him to this turn to spiritualism with an interest in Shankaracharya's Shaivism and Krishna's Vaishnavism. Now comes the nameless, vaporous buoyancy of pure thought without 'isms'.

Centripetal bureaucratic pursuits and ringside political aspirations can often spin a short story very long—stories that have echoed in our circular colonial parliament to more noise than productivity, but this slim tome under review is a short story suitably expanded to remain short! This seems a fresh petal from Varma's thousand-petalled Sahasrar Chakra.

Without spoiling the quick read of *The Lady Who Carried the Monk Across the River*, which I would recommend, especially if a few grey hairs crown your temple, the simple story throws up new 'ways of seeing'. Seeing not in the John Berger way of looking at art, but perhaps with the third intuitive Indian eye. How should one see or hear touch? With all one's senses immediately evoked and brought to action or just en passant, as the duty of the moment?



SUKANT DEEPAK

BOOKS ▼

The Enigma of India

DIEHARD INDOPHILE **JAVIER MORO** IS NOW WORKING ON TWO MAJOR TRAVEL BOOKS ON INDIA

MORO LAMENTS THAT DESPITE INFRASTRUCTURAL DEVELOPMENT IN INDIA, LITTLE ATTENTION IS PAID TO PRESERVING HERITAGE

Javier Moro smiles, saying that seeing his effigy being burnt in front of the Spanish Embassy in India was not really pleasant, but was definitely the best promotion for *The Red Sari: A Dramatized Biography of Sonia Gandhi*—a book tracing Sonia Gandhi's journey from her Italian origins through her marriage to Rajiv Gandhi and her role in Indian politics, which was finally released in India in 2015 after much controversy.

The bestselling author, who co-wrote *Five Past Midnight in Bhopal*—a non-fiction book detailing the 1984 Bhopal gas tragedy—with his uncle Dominique Lapierre, and authored *Passion India: The Story of the Spanish Princess of Kapurthala* (2007), among others, is